

Philipp Hilbert. *Payments operations PM who owns the details, not just the backlog.*

Positioning. Thirteen years of end-to-end product ownership in regulated, detail-heavy domains, from fintech P2P payments to public-sector analytics, with a track record of cutting complexity down to what actually ships.

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Dear Primer team,

I am applying for the Product Manager role on the Financial Operations team. I want to explain why this specific team, not just why Primer.

Reconciliation and settlement operations are where the operational cost of payments lives. The moment a fund doesn't match, the moment an FX rate moves between instruction and settlement, or the moment a currency leg lands in the wrong bucket, these are not abstract product challenges. They have real money attached and require a PM who is genuinely interested in the detail, not one who delegates it to engineering and calls it a technical decision. That description fits me. At the Bundesagentur für Arbeit I owned a national analytics platform where a single indicator computed incorrectly would propagate into published labour-market statistics. I instrumented the ETL pipelines with Dagster and dbt not because the infrastructure team asked me to, but because traceability from source to output is a product property, not an infrastructure one. I think the same way about reconciliation.

My payments background is real, if not ledger-specific. At Kvitt Payment Solutions I built a mobile group-based P2P payment product from zero and took it to acquisition by Sparkasse inside the girocard ecosystem. That meant owning the full flow: the split logic, the settlement timing, the edge cases where a group member pays twice or a transaction sits in limbo. At Scheidt & Bachmann I owned payment and POS product integration in a fully SAFe setup, moving research results into production across a matrix organisation. Neither role put me in front of a treasury FX engine, and I will not pretend otherwise, but the problem-framing and spec-writing discipline required to handle real money and real settlement states is something I have practiced.

The expectation that a PM here defines what is worth solving rather than waiting for a fully formed brief is one I take seriously. At EMIL Group I joined an 18-person delivery organisation that had lost its senior engineers and its client trust, with no clear mandate beyond "fix it." I restructured the team, cut the roadmap, and shipped the Claims Center, a net-new product, from concept to production. At Rohde & Schwarz I pushed into the customer workshops myself because a second-hand summary of user behaviour is not enough to make a good product decision. I discovered that the beautiful UI nobody used and redirected the product to what engineers actually clicked on. That kind of autonomous problem-definition is how I work by default, not on request.

On the technical side: I can read a schema, write a SQL query, review an API contract, and understand why a reconciliation break might be a timing issue rather than a logic error. I have run GitOps delivery with ArgoCD, integrated CI pipelines, and contributed code where necessary to unblock a spec. I am not an engineer, but I am fluent enough that engineers do not have to translate for me, and that makes the feasibility conversation faster and more honest.

Primer's remote-first, writing-heavy, low-bureaucracy culture is the environment I function best in. I have worked remotely since 2017, I write specifications rather than slide decks by preference, and I give direct feedback as a default rather than a style choice. I am looking for a product role where precision is required, not just encouraged.

Best regards, *Philipp Hilbert*
